

Project Assignment 2: Choose Your Challenge and Assemble Your Design Thinking Team

Design Challenge

Redesign the online learning experience for first-generation university students in a world in which access to high-speed internet is unreliable

Selected Team Members

1. Linh Tran (She/Her) - UX Designer, Health Tech Startup
2. Keisha Brown (She/Her) – Learning Designer, Online Platform
3. Carlos Jiménez (He/Him) – Community Development Specialist, NGO
4. Rajiv Menon (He/Him) – AI Product Analyst
5. Tobias Schäfer (He/Him) – Innovation Ethics Consultant

I selected these five members to create a team that can address the multifaceted nature of this wicked problem from complementary angles. The challenge; redesigning online learning for first-generation students with unreliable internet access, requires expertise in user experience, learning design, community context, technology, and ethics.

Linh Tran brings essential UX design skills with specific experience in health technology for low-resource settings. Her focus on empathy, simplicity, and iterative prototyping is exactly what this challenge requires. She understands how to design for users facing contextual constraints, making her invaluable for understanding the lived experience of students struggling with connectivity issues.

Keisha Brown offers specialized expertise in inclusive digital learning environments. Her background in online platform design and universal design principles ensures that whatever solution we develop will prioritize accessibility and learner engagement. She understands that learning experiences must be designed with diverse learners in mind, not just technically functional

Carlos Jiménez provides critical systems thinking and rural stakeholder engagement experience. Working with rural populations in Latin America has given him direct insight into communities with unreliable infrastructure. His participatory design approach will help ensure we don't impose solutions from above but co-design with the communities we aim to serve.

Rajiv Menon bridges data science with design thinking. His ability to translate user insights into algorithm design will help us explore how AI and data-driven approaches might work in low-

bandwidth environments. He can help us understand technical feasibility while maintaining focus on fairness and usability

Tobias Schäfer brings an ethics perspective that is often overlooked in technology design. His values-based design framework will help us uncover hidden assumptions about what constitutes a "good" learning experience. He will challenge us to consider whose values are being served and whether our solutions might inadvertently create new problems.

This combination creates productive tension. Linh and Keisha push for user-centric simplicity. Carlos demands community contextualization. Rajiv explores technical possibilities. Tobias questions underlying assumptions. Together, they represent the diversity of T-shaped people needed for innovation: professional expertise (the stem) combined with the ability to connect across disciplines (the bar).

The team also represents geographic and cultural diversity, Vietnam, USA, Colombia, India, Germany, which will help us avoid a narrow Western-centric perspective on what online learning "should" look like.

First Impressions from the Virtual Team

Documenting Initial Team Member Perspectives

Linh Tran (UX Designer)

We need to prioritize empathy with first-generation students by understanding their daily realities, internet dropping during lectures, sharing devices with family members, and the anxiety of being left behind, then design simple, low-bandwidth solutions that can work offline and sync when connection returns.

Keisha Brown (Learning Designer)

Our focus should be on reimagining learning activities themselves, not just making videos downloadable, but designing asynchronous, text-based, and low-bandwidth learning experiences that maintain engagement and social connection even without constant connectivity.

Carlos Jiménez (Community Development Specialist)

We must involve students and their communities from the start, recognizing that unreliable internet is often a symptom of deeper infrastructure and equity issues, our solution needs to work within existing constraints rather than assuming those constraints will disappear.

Rajiv Menon (AI Product Analyst)

We can leverage lightweight AI models that operate on limited data to personalize learning pathways, predict when connectivity will be available, and optimize content delivery based on bandwidth availability, but only if we design with fairness and transparency in mind.

Tobias Schäfer (Innovation Ethics Consultant)

Before we design anything, we need to critically examine the underlying assumptions: What do we mean by 'successful learning'? Whose definition of educational quality are we using? And could our 'solution' inadvertently create new forms of exclusion or dependence that we haven't considered?